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THE KID WITH TWO HOMES



A bedtime story about a heart that's big enough for two houses.

BY MK PARRISH · \$14

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A NOTE BEFORE THE STORY

When a family changes shape, the children feel it first, and deepest.

A child whose parents live apart carries a small, heavy question that grown-ups don't always hear: *if my family broke, did I? Which house is my real home? Is it my fault?* They pack a bag on Fridays. They keep two toothbrushes. They learn to say goodbye and hello more than most kids ever should.

This is a story for those children. It is gentle on purpose. It doesn't pretend the two houses become one again — because often they don't, and children can tell when a story is lying to them. Instead it tells a truer, kinder thing: that a heart is not a house, and it does not break just because a family changes shape. It grows.

Read it softly. And when it ends, tell the child beside you what they most need to know: *none of this was your fault, you are loved in both homes, and your heart is big enough for all of it.*

THE KID WITH TWO HOMES

There was once a boy named Sam who had two homes, and for a long time he thought that meant something was wrong with him.

It hadn't always been two. Once there had been one house, with both his parents in it, and Sam hadn't thought about "home" at all, the way you don't think about the floor until it moves. But the floor had moved. His parents had come to love each other differently than they used to, and now his mom lived in one house and his dad lived in another, and Sam lived in both.

On Fridays, Sam packed a bag.

He got very good at packing that bag, which is a thing no kid should have to be good at. Toothbrush. The soft shirt. The one stuffed rabbit, named Biscuit, who went everywhere because Biscuit was the only thing that lived in both houses full-time, like Sam. And every Friday, zipping up that bag, Sam felt the small heavy question press on his chest: *Which one is my real home? Where do I actually belong? And — did I do something, to make the one house turn into two?*

He didn't say the question out loud. Kids often don't. But he carried it everywhere, tucked next to Biscuit.

One night at his dad's house, lying in the bed that was his but in the room that was only half his life, Sam finally let a little of the question leak out. "I don't know where home is anymore," he said, very quietly, mostly to Biscuit.

But his dad was in the doorway, and his dad heard.

His dad came and sat on the edge of the bed, and he didn't rush to fix it, which was the right thing, because some things can't be fixed, only understood. For a while he just sat. Then he said, "Can I tell you a secret about homes?"

Sam nodded.

"When you were born," his dad said, "you were smaller than Biscuit. And your mom and I looked at you, and both of us — in what became two different houses — felt the exact same enormous thing. That never split in two, Sam. It didn't divide up when we did. Your mom's whole heart, and my whole heart. You didn't get half of each. You got *all* of both. That's not less than other kids have. That's more."

Sam thought about that. "But which house is my *real* home?"

And his dad said the thing Sam would remember for the rest of his life.

"Here's the secret. Home was never the house." He tapped Sam gently, right on the chest, over his heart. "Home is *this*. And you carry it with you, back and forth, every Friday, in that bag with Biscuit. That's why both houses feel like home when you're in them — because *you* brought the home. You're not a kid who lost his home, Sam. You're a kid who's big enough to make home in two places. That's a superpower. Most people only know how to do it in one."

Sam looked down at his own chest, where his dad had tapped. He thought about his mom's house — the smell of it, the squeaky third stair, the way the morning light came in. And his dad's house — this bed, this quiet, the tree outside this window. And for the first time, he understood that they were both true. Both real. Both his.

"And Sam," his dad added, quieter now, because this part mattered most of all, "the thing that changed between your mom and me — that was grown-up stuff. It was never, ever about you. You didn't do it, and you couldn't have stopped it, and if you'd been the best kid in the entire world it would have happened just the same, and you *were* the best kid in the entire world. Two homes doesn't mean you were too much. It means you were, and are, completely loved. Twice over."

Sam felt the small heavy question lift off his chest and float away into the dark, and it did not come back to sit on him the same way ever again.

He still packed his bag on Fridays. That part didn't change. Some things in a story don't get to change back, and this one didn't. But packing the bag felt different now. He wasn't leaving home to go to some other place. He was carrying his home — the one in his chest, next to Biscuit — from people who loved him, to people who loved him.

And that, it turned out, was a fine way to grow up. Not the way he would have chosen. But fine. More than fine. Full.

Two houses. Two bedrooms. Two of almost everything.

And one heart, big enough for all of it, that had never once been broken — only, quietly, grown.

THE END — AND YOUR BEGINNING

If your family has changed shape — if you pack a bag, and keep two toothbrushes, and say more goodbyes than you think is fair — this story was written for you.

Here is what Sam learned, and what is just as true for you: home was never the house. Home is the thing in your chest that you carry back and forth, the love that lives in you and travels with you. Your family changing shape did not break you. You are not too much. You did not cause it, and you could not have stopped it, and you are loved — completely, and in both places.

A heart is not a house. It doesn't crack down the middle when a family changes. It stretches. It makes room. It learns to hold two of everything, and that is not a wound.

It's a superpower.

Pack your bag. Carry your home. You belong in both places, because you bring the belonging with you.

You always did. You always will.

This is a tale from **The Little Rewrites** *— bedtime stories from MK Parrish for children who are learning that they get to write their own happily ever after, exactly as they are. More stories, and the free read-aloud guide for grown-ups, are waiting at* **mkparrish.com.**

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